
PACK 1

PM Essentials: Your First 90 Days

One workbook that builds its own program status report.



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Welcome & overview

You just got handed a program, or you are about to. This pack is what an experienced DoD program manager does in the first 90 days, built as one Excel workbook instead of five separate files.

It is not a set of blank forms. The Risk Register already knows the sixteen things that kill DoD programs. The RACI already knows that the PEO owns the milestone decision and the Contracting Officer owns the mod. The First 90 Days checklist is the list an experienced PM keeps in their head. The Spend Plan knows your appropriation's obligation goal. You overwrite the examples with your program, and the Dashboard tab reads all of it and builds your PEO brief.

The PM Briefing Deck is the only separate file. Every slide's speaker notes tell you the questions leadership will actually ask and what to say when your light is red.

This guide walks you through every tab: what it does, why it matters, and how to use it. Start with the Dashboard so you can see where everything lands, then work the tabs in the order below.

WHAT'S UPDATED IN THIS EDITION

Reflects FAC 2025-06 (effective Oct 1, 2025), the FY26 NDAA, and CMMC as of late September 2026.

- Simplified Acquisition Threshold (SAT) updated to \$350,000 (FAC 2025-06, effective Oct 1, 2025)
- Micro-Purchase Threshold (MPT) updated to \$15,000
- TINA / certified cost & pricing data: \$10M on DoD contracts entered into after June 30, 2026 (FY26 NDAA sec. 1804); \$2.5M otherwise
- Competition J&A approval threshold: \$900,000
- EVM at \$50M, validated EVMS at \$100M (DFARS class deviation 2026-O0011, Feb 1, 2026)
- CMMC Phase 1 (since Nov 10, 2025): CMMC clauses in new contracts; self-assessments posted in SPRS
- CMMC Phase 2 (C3PAO certification for Level 2) suspended July 13, 2026, with no new date. Risk Register R-006 and R-016 rewritten to match
- September 2026 rebuild: IGCE Calculator and RFP Compliance Matrix retired from this pack; Program Dashboard, First 90 Days Checklist, and Spend Plan added; all tools consolidated into one workbook

Quick start checklist

Not sure where to start? Here's the recommended order. You don't need to use all five tools on day one, but this sequence gets you set up the fastest. Read this first, then flip to each tool's page for the full walkthrough.

1 Open the Dashboard and fill in the three header cells

Program, your name, as-of date. Everything else on that tab fills itself in.

2 Work the First 90 Days tab in order

Orient, then Assess, then Act. Mark each item as you go. The Dashboard tracks your progress.

3 Fix the RACI before anything else

Know who owns each decision. Every row already has an Accountable owner; replace the roles with names.

4 Rescore the Risk Register for your program

Keep the sixteen risks, change the probability and impact. The Risk Map redraws itself.

5 Load the Spend Plan and post actuals monthly

Appropriation, budget authority, planned obligations. The BEHIND flag is your early warning.

6 Brief from the Dashboard and the Deck

Print the Dashboard for your PEO. Read the speaker notes before every PMR.

Questions? Visit acqlerate.com for tutorials, walkthroughs, and the full Acqlerate template library.

Program Dashboard

What it is

A one-page program status that reads every other tab in the workbook. You fill in three cells (program, your name, as-of date). It fills in the rest.

THE ANALOGY

It is the gauge cluster in a truck. You do not drive by looking at the engine; you drive by looking at the gauges. The gauges are only useful because they are wired to the engine.

Why it matters

Leadership does not want your spreadsheets. They want to know if the money is on plan, what the top risks are, and whether you have the program under control. The Dashboard answers all three on one printed page, and it cannot drift out of sync with the detail because it is computed from the detail.

What's inside

- MONEY: appropriation, budget authority, obligated to date, percent of plan achieved, remaining to your first-year obligation goal, and a BEHIND / ON PLAN / AHEAD light.
- RISK: counts of HIGH, MEDIUM, and LOW, plus a live list of every open HIGH risk by ID and title.
- FIRST 90 DAYS: percent complete for Orient, Assess, and Act.
- ACCOUNTABILITY: decisions tracked and how many are missing an Accountable owner. Should read zero.
- A "How to read this" column explaining what each light means and what to do about it.

How to use it

1 Fill in the header

Program name, your name, and the as-of date. Nothing else on this tab is typed.

2 Work the other tabs

Every number here comes from Spend Plan, Risk Register, First 90 Days, and RACI. Update those; this updates.

3 Print it for your PEO

Landscape, one page. Lead with whatever is red.

First 90 Days Checklist

What it is

Thirty things to do when you inherit a DoD program, in three phases: Orient (days 1 to 30), Assess (31 to 60), Act (61 to 90). Each has a status, an owner, and a place for evidence.

Why it matters

The first 90 days decide whether you run the program or the program runs you. New PMs lose that window finding out things they should have been told: which appropriation expires this year, which risk the last PM was hiding, who actually has authority over the contract mod. This list is what an experienced PM already knows to go find.

What's inside

- Orient: baseline, stakeholders, contracts, spend status, CPARS, RACI, near-term milestones, CMMC posture, the outgoing PM's top risks.
- Assess: rescore risks, reconcile obligations, walk the IMS, review EVM if it applies, audit CDRLs, meet DCMA and DCAA, staffing, open mods, test readiness, draft your first PMR.
- Act: deliver the PMR, publish the battle rhythm, refresh the register, adjust the spend plan, set CPARS expectations, lock milestone criteria, start a decision log, brief lessons learned.
- Status dropdown per item (Not Started, In Progress, Done, N/A) with per-phase and overall percent complete.

How to use it

1 Do them in order

Orient before Assess before Act. Skipping ahead is how you brief a risk you do not understand.

2 Mark status honestly

Done means done, with evidence in the Notes column. The Dashboard reads this tab.

3 Add your own

Every program has three or four items nobody else would think of. Add rows; the formulas extend.

Spend Plan

What it is

A monthly plan of obligations and expenditures for one fiscal year, one appropriation line, against your appropriation's first-year obligation goal. Post actuals each month and it tells you whether you are on plan.

THE ANALOGY

It is a fuel gauge with a trip computer. The gauge tells you how much is left. The trip computer tells you whether you will make it at this rate, which is the question that matters.

Why it matters

An appropriation that expires unobligated is money you had and lost, and it is the single most avoidable failure in program finance. The failure never shows up in September. It shows up in February as "a little behind," and nobody acts on it. This tab makes "a little behind" a red cell in February.

What's inside

- Header inputs: fiscal year, appropriation (O&M, RDT&E, Procurement), total budget authority. Years available and the obligation goal fill in from a lookup table.
- Twelve monthly rows: planned and actual obligations, cumulative both ways, variance in dollars and percent, and a BEHIND / ON PLAN / AHEAD flag at plus or minus 10 percent. Same structure for expenditures.
- Year-to-date block: months posted, planned vs. obligated to date, percent of budget authority obligated, percent of plan achieved, remaining to goal, overall status.
- Pre-loaded with a realistic S-curve on a 4.15 million dollar O&M line, actuals posted through March, so you can see how it behaves before you clear it.

How to use it

1 Set the header

Appropriation drives the goal. Budget authority drives every percentage.

2 Enter the plan

Planned obligations by month. If you do not have a plan, the S-curve example is a reasonable starting shape.

3 Post actuals monthly

Actual obligations and expenditures. Leave future months blank; the flags only trip on posted months.

4 Act on BEHIND in Q2

If the line is red in February, you still have time. If it is red in August, you have a story to write.

Risk Register and Risk Map

What it is

A register of sixteen pre-loaded DoD program risks with probability, impact, mitigation, and contingency written, and a 5 by 5 map that plots every risk by ID so you can see where they cluster.

THE ANALOGY

A weather forecast. You cannot stop the storm, but you can see it coming, and the map shows you where it will hit hardest.

Why it matters

A blank risk register is a test of what you already know. This one is a checklist of what experienced PMs worry about: Nunn-McCurdy breach, continuing resolution impact, CMMC status, requirements creep, key personnel loss. You will delete some and rescore the rest, but you will not start from a blank page wondering what you forgot.

What's inside

- Sixteen risks across Technical, Schedule, Cost, External, and Programmatic categories, each with a written mitigation and contingency.
- Probability times Impact scoring with automatic HIGH / MEDIUM / LOW, color-scaled.
- Summary counts by level, category, and status, which the Dashboard reads.
- Risk Map: a static scoring key plus a "Where Your Risks Land" grid that lists risk IDs in the right cell. Print it for the weekly review.
- CMMC is pre-loaded twice: R-006 for the rules changing mid-contract (Phase 2 C3PAO assessments were suspended July 2026) and R-016 for subcontractors whose SPRS status is not current. If your program handles CUI and a sub is not current, score R-016 HIGH.

How to use it

1 Keep the sixteen

Delete only what genuinely does not apply. Most of these apply to most programs.

2 Rescore for your program

Change probability and impact. The score, level, summary, Map, and Dashboard all update.

3 Name an owner per HIGH

The Dashboard lists every open HIGH. If you cannot name the owner, that is your first finding.

4 Review monthly

Risks change. Close them, re-scope them, add new ones from the First 90 Days assessment.

RACI

What it is

Twenty-five program decisions, one row each, with who is Responsible, Accountable, Consulted, and Informed. Four fields per row. No grid.

THE ANALOGY

If the program were a flight: who is flying (Responsible), who owns the aircraft (Accountable), who air traffic control talks to (Consulted), who is notified when you land (Informed).

Why it matters

Most RACI matrices die because they are grids: adding a decision means filling ten columns, so nobody adds decisions, so the RACI is out of date by month two. This one is a list. Adding a decision is one row. And every row already has exactly one Accountable owner, which is the only rule that matters and the one most templates break.

What's inside

- Twenty-five decisions from Program Initiation to Lessons Learned, pre-mapped to PM, PEO, CO, COR, DCMA, DCAA, Contractor PM, Systems Engineer, Finance, and Legal.
- Responsible and Accountable get a dropdown of the standard roles. Consulted and Informed take comma-separated lists.
- Accountable column highlighted. The Dashboard counts blanks; it should read zero.
- RACI Instructions tab with role definitions and how to customize.

How to use it

1 Replace roles with names

"PEO" is a role. "Col. Reyes" is a person who can be asked. Names make the RACI real.

2 Brief it at kickoff

Everyone needs to know their lane from day one. Store it with the Program Management Plan.

3 Update when roles change

Personnel turnover is on the Risk Register for a reason. Keep this current.

PM Briefing Deck

What it is

A twelve-slide PowerPoint template for your program status review, with a difference: every slide's speaker notes tell you what leadership will actually ask on that slide, and what to say if your light is red.

Why it matters

The slides are not the hard part of a PMR. The questions are. New PMs get ambushed on the cost slide with "do you believe that EAC?" or on the risk slide with "who owns that?" The notes put the question in front of you before you are standing in front of them.

What's inside

- Twelve slides: cover, agenda, executive summary with traffic lights, program status, schedule with SPI, cost and EVM with KPI cards, risk status, technical progress, contractor performance, issues and actions, way forward, backup.
- Speaker notes on every slide in two parts: WHAT LEADERSHIP WILL ASK, and IF THIS SLIDE IS RED.
- Designed to be fed from the workbook: the Dashboard is your executive summary, the Risk Map is your risk slide, the Spend Plan is your cost backup.

How to use it

1 Read the notes first

Before you build the slide, read what it has to answer.

2 Paste from the workbook

Dashboard on slide 3, Risk Map on slide 7, Spend Plan year-to-date block on slide 6 or in backup.

3 Delete what you do not need

Not every review needs twelve slides. Every review needs the executive summary and the way forward.